

The Oregon Trail

Put the westward journey in order along a 2,000-mile trail, and ask what it meant for the Native nations whose homelands the wagons crossed.

? Historical challenge

In the 1840s to the 1860s, hundreds of thousands of people loaded covered wagons and set out on the roughly 2,000-mile Oregon Trail to build new lives in the West. What did the journey look like from start to finish — and how did it change the land and the Native nations who already lived there? Follow the trail and put the journey in order.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Oregon National Historic Trail — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

The route, its landmarks, and the wagon trains that traveled it.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What are three places along the trail, in order?
- How long did the journey take?

SOURCES 2

Trails to Utah and the Pacific: Diaries and Letters, 1846–1869 — Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Real diaries and letters written by people on the overland journey.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did a traveler worry about or hope for?
- What does a diary tell you that a map cannot?

SOURCES 3

War on the Oregon & California Trails — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How the wagon traffic strained the Native nations along the route.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did the trail affect Native nations?
- Why might the same journey look different to different people?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The Oregon Trail

1840s–1860s

Independence, Missouri to Oregon's Willamette Valley

1 Moment 1

Independence, Missouri — each spring, families gather, load their wagons, and set out west together.



2 Moment 2

Along the Platte River past Chimney Rock, Nebraska — wagons roll across the flat prairie past a tall rock spire.



3 Moment 3

Fort Laramie, Wyoming — a trading fort where travelers rest, make repairs, and buy supplies before the mountains.



4 Moment 4

South Pass, Wyoming — the wide, gentle gap where wagons cross the Rocky Mountains.



5 Moment 5

Fort Hall to Oregon City — the trail follows the Snake and Columbia rivers to the journey's end in the Willamette Valley.

Important people / groups

Emigrant families — farmers seeking land and a new start

Trail guides and mountain men — led the wagon trains

Native nations (Pawnee, Lakota, Shoshone, Cayuse, Umatilla) — lived on the lands the trail crossed

Fur traders and fort keepers — traded supplies to passing travelers

Missionaries — among the first wagon parties west

Why did this matter?

Hundreds of thousands of people crossed the Oregon Trail to build new lives in the West, but their journey also changed the land and deeply disrupted the Native nations who had lived there for generations.

One question I still have

What was a day on the trail really like for a kid your age — and how might the same journey have looked to a Native child watching the wagons roll through their homeland?

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your trail order with a partner. Did you put the moments in the same sequence?
- Which moment do you think was the hardest part of the journey? Why?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The Oregon Trail (~1840s–1860s) ran about 2,000 miles from Independence, Missouri to Oregon's Willamette Valley; an estimated 300,000–400,000 emigrants traveled it in covered wagons at about 12–15 miles a day (4–6 months). Disease (especially cholera) was the biggest killer. The trail crossed the homelands of many Native nations, and the wagon traffic consumed the grass, game, wood, and water they depended on.

Common misconceptions

- The West was not empty — Native nations had lived there for generations.
- Most deaths came from disease, not from conflict.
- 'Manifest Destiny' was an idea used to justify expansion, not a neutral description of it.

Vocabulary

emigrant, wagon train, prairie, Continental Divide, South Pass, Manifest Destiny.

Historical context

Great Migration wagon train of 1843 (~1,000 people); route crossed present-day KS, NE, WY, ID, OR; South Pass crossed the Rockies; cholera the leading cause of death.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Tell the story of the Oregon Trail in your own words, in order. Use at least three moments and name at least two groups the journey affected — including the Native nations whose homelands it crossed.